

ALLEY

1. Passage anchor

> “Still, as an occasional read, this kind of novel is **right up my alley**.”

Passage meaning

right up my alley = exactly suited to my interests, tastes, or abilities

正合我口味；正是我喜歡的類型；正中下懷

Here, the speaker means this type of novel fits their personal reading taste very well.

Practice

1. Psychological fiction is **right up my alley**.

心理小說**很合我的口味**。

2. A quiet café with books and jazz is **right up her alley**.

有書和爵士樂的安靜咖啡店**正是她喜歡的類型**。

Core meanings of ALLEY

2. alley — narrow passage or street

= a narrow passage between or behind buildings

小巷；後巷；窄巷

Examples

1. We walked through a narrow **alley**.

我們走過一條狹窄的**小巷**。

2. The restaurant is hidden in a small **alley** behind the market.

那家餐廳藏在市場後面的一條**小巷**裡。

This is the central literal sense.

3. back alley

= narrow lane behind buildings, often away from the main street

後巷；後街小巷

Examples

1. The entrance is in the **back alley**.
入口在**後巷**。
2. They found an old bicycle in the **back alley**.
他們在**後巷**發現了一輛舊單車。

Bowling

4. bowling alley

= place where people play ten-pin bowling
保齡球館

Examples

1. We went to the **bowling alley** after dinner.
晚飯後我們去了**保齡球館**。
2. The new **bowling alley** has twenty lanes.
新的**保齡球館**有二十條球道。

Very common lexicalized compound.

5. alley — bowling lane

= lane along which a bowling ball is rolled
保齡球道

Examples

1. The ball rolled straight down the **alley**.
保齡球沿著**球道**直滾下去。
2. Keep your feet behind the line at the start of the **alley**.
雙腳要保持在**球道**起點線後面。

Less common than **lane**, but established.

Sports / court passage

6. alley — narrow side area in some sports

= narrow strip or channel at the side of a playing area

側邊狹長區域；邊線區

Most notably in tennis:

doubles alley

= extra strip used in doubles but not singles

雙打邊線區

Examples

1. The ball landed in the **doubles alley**.

球落在**雙打邊線區**。

2. In singles, the **alley** is out of bounds.

在單打中，這條**側邊區域**屬界外。

Figurative idiom

7. right up someone's alley

= very suitable for someone's interests, personality, skills, or preferences

很合某人口味；正是某人擅長 / 喜歡的

This is the exact passage use.

Examples

1. That kind of puzzle is **right up his alley**.

那種謎題**正是他擅長的**。

2. A reflective novel like this is **right up my alley**.

這種反思性的小說**很合我的口味**。

8. up someone's alley

= suited to someone's interests or abilities

****符合某人的興趣 / 專長****

Examples

1. This project is ****up your alley****.

這個專案****很適合你****。

2. Mystery novels are definitely ****up her alley****.

推理小說****絕對很合她的口味****。

****Right up**** simply makes the fit sound stronger.

Other lexicalized uses

9. alley cat

= cat that lives outdoors around streets and alleys, often without an owner

****流浪貓；街貓****

Examples

1. An ****alley cat**** was sleeping near the bins.

一隻****流浪貓****睡在垃圾桶附近。

2. The shelter rescued several ****alley cats****.

收容所救了幾隻****街貓****。

10. blind alley

A. literal

= alley with no exit

****死巷****

B. figurative

= course of action or investigation that leads nowhere

****死胡同；行不通的方向****

Examples

1. The road ends in a **blind alley**.

這條路最後通往一條**死巷**。

2. That line of research turned out to be a **blind alley**.

那個研究方向最後證明是條**死胡同**。

High-value figurative expression.

Related forms / compounds

11. alleyway

= narrow passage between buildings

小巷；**窄道**

Examples

1. The café is down a narrow **alleyway**.

咖啡店就在一條狹窄的**小巷**裡。

2. The **alleyway** was poorly lit.

那條**小巷**光線很暗。

12. bowling alley

= building or venue with bowling lanes

保齡球館

This is much more common than using **alley** alone to mean the venue.

Key contrasts

13. alley vs lane

alley

= usually a narrow passage between or behind buildings

小巷；**後巷**

lane

= can mean a narrow road, traffic lane, swimming lane, bowling lane, etc.

****小路；車道；泳道；球道****

Compare:

> back alley

> 後巷

> bowling lane

> 保齡球道

14. alley vs street

****street****

= ordinary public road in a town or city, usually wider and more prominent

****街道****

****alley****

= much narrower passage, often between or behind buildings

****小巷****

15. alley vs passage

****passage****

= general narrow route through or between places

****通道****

****alley****

= usually an outdoor narrow urban passage

****小巷****

16. right up my alley vs my cup of tea

Both can mean:

****很合我口味；正是我喜歡的****

But:

****right up my alley****

= often emphasizes suitability to interests, taste, or skills

****my cup of tea****

= more directly emphasizes liking/preference

Compare:

> Data analysis is right up my alley.

> 數據分析正是我的專長 / 興趣。

> Horror films aren't my cup of tea.

> 恐怖片不是我的菜。

Meaning map

The central literal concept of ****alley**** is:

****a narrow passage****

From this develop:

Urban space

alley

→ ****小巷 / 後巷****

Bowling

bowling alley

→ ****保齡球館****

Bowling lane

alley

→ ****保齡球道****

Tennis

doubles alley

→ ****雙打邊線區****

And figuratively:

Passage

right up my alley

→ ****正合我的興趣 / 口味****

The idiom likely builds on the idea of something being directly “in your lane/path,” though modern learners should simply treat it as a fixed expression.

MCQ-ready master list

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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alley — narrow passage	建築物之間或後方的狹窄小巷 / 後巷
back alley	建築物後方的後巷 / 窄巷
bowling alley — venue	設有保齡球道的保齡球館
alley — bowling lane	保齡球滾動的球道
doubles alley — tennis	網球雙打使用、單打不使用的側邊狹長區域
right up someone's alley	非常符合某人的興趣、口味或專長
up someone's alley	適合某人的興趣或能力
alley cat	在街巷生活、通常無主的流浪貓
blind alley — literal	沒有出口的死巷
blind alley — figurative	不會有結果、行不通的方向；死胡同
alleyway	狹窄的小巷 / 通道

Passage recap

> “...this kind of novel is ****right up my alley****.”

Here:

****right up my alley**** = ****exactly the kind of thing I personally like or am interested in****

Best Traditional Chinese:

* ****正合我口味****

* ****正是我喜歡的類型****

* ****很合我的興趣****

* contextually: ****真的很合我口味****

Natural contextual translation:

****作為偶爾閱讀的一種選擇，這類小說真的很合我口味。****

Passage MCQ-ready meaning

****right up someone's alley****

= ****very well suited to someone's interests, tastes, or abilities****

****正合某人口味；正是某人喜歡 / 擅長的****

The key distinction is:

> ****alley****

> → 小巷

but:

> ****right up my alley****

> → ****正合我口味 / 正是我的興趣所在****

So in the passage, there is no literal street or alley. It is a fixed idiom meaning that reflective, emotionally meaningful novels are exactly the sort of books the speaker enjoys.